

The Ultimate AI Desktop

Why Mac mini is the best AI computer today

—By **Vyom Ramani**

The Mac Mini is out of stock. Not the kind of product stock issues that are seen from time to time just before a release of a new product by Apple, but truly, structurally out of stock – a number of different models have been backordered for many weeks. At Apple's Q2 2026 earnings call, Tim Cook himself drew attention to the demand for the Mac Mini, connecting it to the rise of agentic AI systems.

This all boils down to the architecture of the processor used in the Mac Mini. The M4 processor from Apple employs a unified memory architecture, where the CPU, GPU, and Neural Engine use the same memory space. Given that the AI tasks involve transferring massive amounts of data between different processors all the time, the significance of that cannot be overstated. A Mac Mini equipped with 24GB of unified memory will comfortably support a capable large language model, with significantly lower energy consumption than an x86 system with similar performance. Neural Engine, with its 38 TOPS rating on the M4 processor, is efficient enough to do

inference of such models as Qwen 3 or Llama 3 using Ollama locally.

This is in contrast to the alternatives. Both Snapdragon X Elite and Intel Core Ultra laptops have made some considerable improvements, and the figures in terms of NPU capability are rather impressive. However, they come with significant premiums – competent



Copilot+ laptops start at twice the price of Mac Mini – and the ecosystem in terms of local AI inferencing on Windows is still lagging behind compared to the one offered on macOS. MLX, Apple's machine learning framework optimised for Apple silicon, offers a mature and documented process for inference on Apple computers that doesn't have any equivalents on the Windows platform.

And then there is the issue of agency which makes this case for the Mac Mini even more interesting. Platforms such as OpenClaw and Mac version of Perplexity app have made an autonomous AI node – a computer that works independently from user's actions – very popular concept. With its headless capabilities, power efficiency, and relative affordability, Mac Mini was practically built for this use case, despite being developed without taking it into account. Perplexity itself documents the Mac Mini as its recommended hardware choice for running the agent.

The M5 chipset refresh, that is expected to arrive later in 2026, is rumoured to push even harder on AI performance with a freshly redesigned Neural Engine. But the current M4 model already makes the case clearly enough. While the rest of the industry is still debating what an PC specifically made for on-device AI should look like, Apple's smallest desktop has quietly become the answer. tinyurl.com/nvn8912d

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